

SCAFFOLD

SUPPORTS TERTIARY WHY

FOR WHAT-HOW · HOW-WHAT

The Narrative Arc Template

A five-beat structure that converts detail-rich content into a meaning-led story. **The narrative is assembled, not inspired**, from material you already have.

THE DRAIN

Turning content into story is purpose work: it requires deciding what it all means and to whom. WHAT-HOW and HOW-WHAT profiles present the way they work, completely and in order, and audiences wired for meaning check out by slide three, taking the work's reputation with them.

WHAT THIS TOOL DOES

The arc is a fixed five-beat skeleton that any body of content can be poured into. Each beat has a plain question; answering the five questions in order produces a story-shaped deliverable without requiring a storyteller's instinct. The same rigor that built the content now assembles its narrative.

The five beats

- | | |
|-------------|--|
| 1 Situation | Where things stand, in terms the audience already accepts. One beat, not five. |
| 2 Stakes | Why standing still costs something. This beat earns the audience's attention. |
| 3 Shift | The insight or change, the one thing this deliverable exists to say. |
| 4 So-what | What it means for the people in the room. Borrow from the Translator. |
| 5 Ask | The specific decision or action requested. Stories without asks are entertainment. |

HOW TO USE IT

- 1 **Write the Shift beat first.** One sentence: the single thing they must take away. Every other beat serves it.
- 2 **Ration the Situation.** Your instinct is to establish everything. The arc allows one beat of context; the rest goes to the appendix.
- 3 **Pour, don't rewrite.** Map existing sections to beats. Most of the work is reordering and cutting, not creating.
- 4 **Read it aloud once.** A story has a sound. If a beat clunks, it is usually Situation overgrowing its slot.

WHAT IT WON'T DO

The arc structures meaning; it cannot invent significance that is not there, if the Shift beat is empty, the finding is about the work, not the template. And not every artifact needs an arc, reference material should stay reference-shaped. Use it where an audience must be moved.

IN THE KIT

Arc planning sheet

Beat-mapping worksheet

Before/after example deck

PAIRS WELL WITH

Tool 24 The So-What Translator · **Tool 40** Mixed-Audience Deck Structure · **Tool 29** The Opening Line Habit